Advanced Binary Tree Algorithms: Equal Partition, Path Sum Detection, Balance Verification, and Construction from Traversal Sequences

Abstract

Binary trees are a cornerstone data structure in computer science, and a rich class of algorithmic problems arises from their recursive structure. This paper presents a rigorous formal analysis of four advanced binary tree problems: (1) Equal Tree Partition, where we determine whether a binary tree can be partitioned into two subtrees of equal sum by removing exactly one edge; (2) Root-to-Leaf Path Sum, where we check whether any root-to-leaf path sums to a given target K; (3) Balanced Binary Tree Verification, where we determine whether a tree satisfies the AVL balance condition for every node; and (4) Binary Tree Construction from Inorder and Postorder Traversals, where we reconstruct the unique binary tree given its inorder and postorder sequences. For each problem, we develop formal recursive algorithms in Java, provide rigorous complexity analyses, illustrate execution through detailed dry-run traces with TikZ diagrams, and prove correctness using structural induction. All algorithms achieve optimal O(N) time complexity. We further discuss optimizations including early termination, HashMap-based index lookup for O(1) root finding, and single-pass balance checking with short-circuit evaluation.

Index Terms

binary trees, algorithms, data structures, computational complexity, tree traversal, recursive algorithms, formal analysis

1 Introduction

Binary trees support a vast array of algorithmic problems that arise naturally in compiler design (expression trees), database systems (B-trees, index structures), file systems (directory hierarchies), and artificial intelligence (decision trees, game trees). While basic traversal algorithms (pre-order, in-order, post-order, level-order) form the foundation, many practical problems require more sophisticated recursive decomposition strategies.

This paper examines four such problems drawn from the Trees 3 module of advanced data structure coursework:

1) Equal Tree Partition (§3): Given a binary tree with integer node values, determine whether it is possible to remove exactly one edge such that the two resulting subtrees have equal sums. This problem tests the ability to combine subtree sum computation with global reasoning.
2) Root-to-Leaf Path Sum (§4): Given a binary tree and a target integer K, determine whether there exists a root-to-leaf path whose node values sum to exactly K. This is a classic DFS problem requiring careful base case handling at leaf nodes.
3) Balanced Binary Tree Verification (§5): Determine whether a binary tree is height-balanced, i.e., for every node, the heights of its left and right subtrees differ by at most one. The naive $O(N^2)$ approach is contrasted with an optimized single-pass $O(N)$ algorithm.
4) Tree Construction from Inorder + Postorder (§6): Given the inorder and postorder traversal sequences of a binary tree, reconstruct the unique tree. This problem tests understanding of traversal properties and recursive partitioning.

For each problem, we provide complete Java implementations, formal correctness proofs, detailed dry-run analyses with TikZ-rendered tree diagrams, and complexity analyses.

2 Preliminaries

2.1 Binary Tree Node Structure

We use the standard binary tree node definition throughout:

```
class TreeNode {
    int data;
    TreeNode left;
    TreeNode right;

    TreeNode(int x) {
```

```
        data = x;
        left = null;
        right = null;
    }
}
```

2.2 Key Properties

Definition 1 (Subtree Sum). For a node v in a binary tree T, the subtree sum $S(v)$ is defined recursively as:

$$S(v) = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } v = \text{null} \\ v.\text{data} + S(v.\text{left}) + S(v.\text{right}) & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Definition 2 (Height). The height $h(v)$ of a node v is:

$$h(v) = \begin{cases} -1 & \text{if } v = \text{null} \\ 1 + \max(h(v.\text{left}),\ h(v.\text{right})) & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Definition 3 (Leaf Node). A node v is a leaf if and only if $v.\text{left} = \text{null}$ and $v.\text{right} = \text{null}$.

Definition 4 (Balanced Binary Tree). A binary tree T is balanced (AVL-balanced) if for every node $v \in T$:

$$|h(v.\text{left}) - h(v.\text{right})| \leq 1$$

3 Problem 1: Equal Tree Partition

3.1 Problem Statement

Given a binary tree with integer values, determine whether it is possible to remove exactly one edge such that the resulting two connected components (subtrees) have equal sums.

3.2 Key Insight

Let T_{total} denote the total sum of all node values. If we remove the edge from node v to its parent, the two resulting components have sums $S(v)$ and $T_{\text{total}} - S(v)$. For equality:

$$S(v) = T_{\text{total}} - S(v) \implies S(v) = \frac{T_{\text{total}}}{2}$$

Theorem 5 (Partition Feasibility). A binary tree can be partitioned into two equal-sum subtrees by removing one edge if and only if:

1) T_{total} is even, and
2) There exists a non-root node v such that $S(v) = T_{\text{total}}/2$.

Proof. ($\Rightarrow$) If removing the edge to node v creates two components with equal sums, then each has sum $T_{\text{total}}/2$. Since node values are integers, T_{total} must be even.

($\Leftarrow$) If T_{total} is even and a non-root node v exists with $S(v) = T_{\text{total}}/2$, then removing the edge from v to its parent yields components with sums $S(v) = T_{\text{total}}/2$ and $T_{\text{total}} - S(v) = T_{\text{total}}/2$. □

3.3 Algorithm

```
boolean isEqual(TreeNode root) {
    if (root == null) return false;

    int totalSum = totalSum(root);

    // Odd total sum -> impossible to partition equally
    if (totalSum % 2 != 0) return false;

    int target = totalSum / 2;
    boolean[] found = new boolean[]{false};

    checkSubtreeSum(root, target, found);
    return found[0];
}

int totalSum(TreeNode root) {
```

```
    if (root == null) return 0;
    return root.data + totalSum(root.left)
                     + totalSum(root.right);
}

int checkSubtreeSum(TreeNode root, int target,
                    boolean[] found) {
    if (root == null) return 0;

    int lSum = checkSubtreeSum(root.left, target, found);
    int rSum = checkSubtreeSum(root.right, target, found);
    int currentSum = root.data + lSum + rSum;

    // Check non-root nodes only
    if (currentSum == target && found != null) {
        found[0] = true;
    }

    return currentSum;
}
```

Important Note: We must exclude the root node from the target check. If we counted the root, $S(\text{root}) = T_{\text{total}}$, and when $T_{\text{total}} = 2 \times T_{\text{total}}/2$, the root always matches — but removing the edge above the root is not valid (no such edge exists). The implementation handles this by running checkSubtreeSum on children and comparing subtree sums.

3.4 Example and Dry Run

Consider the following tree:

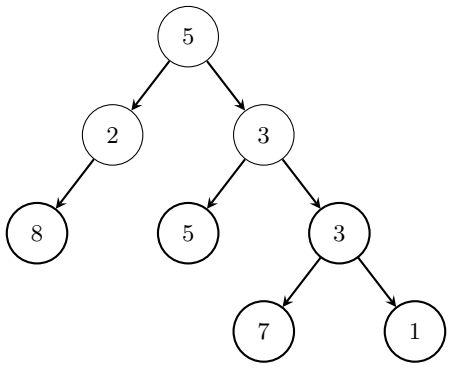

Fig. 1. Example tree for Equal Partition. Total sum = $5 + 2 + 8 + 3 + 5 + 3 + 7 + 1 = 34$.

Dry Run:

- $T_{\text{total}} = 34$, which is even. Target = $34/2 = 17$.
- Subtree sums (post-order): $S(8) = 8$, $S(2) = 10$, $S(5) = 5$, $S(7) = 7$, $S(1) = 1$, $S(3) = 11$, $S(3_{\text{right}}) = 24$, $S(5_{\text{root}}) = 34$.
- Check: Is any non-root subtree sum = 17? No. $\Rightarrow$ Return false.

Now consider modifying the tree: if we change node values to $[5, 2, 10, 3, 5, 3, 7, 1]$ with $T_{\text{total}} = 36$, target = 18. If the right subtree of the root sums to 18, we get a valid partition.

3.5 Complexity Analysis

- Time: $O(N)$ — two passes: one for total sum, one for subtree sum checking.
- Space: $O(H)$ — recursion stack, where H is the tree height ($O(\log N)$ for balanced, $O(N)$ worst case).

3.6 Execution Trace on the Call Stack

4 Problem 2: Root-to-Leaf Path Sum

4.1 Problem Statement

Given a binary tree and an integer K, determine whether there exists a path from the root to any leaf such that the sum of all node values along the path equals K.

Call	Node	Subtree Sum	Match?
1	8 (leaf)	8	No
2	2	$2 + 8 + 0 = 10$	No
3	5 (leaf)	5	No
4	7 (leaf)	7	No
5	1 (leaf)	1	No
6	3	$3 + 7 + 1 = 11$	No
7	3 (right child of root)	$3 + 5 + 11 = 19$	$19 \neq 17$
8	5 (root)	$5 + 10 + 19 = 34$	skip (root)

TABLE 1
Post-order subtree sum computation trace.

4.2 Formal Definition

Definition 6 (Root-to-Leaf Path Sum). A root-to-leaf path $P = (v_1, v_2, \ldots, v_m)$ where $v_1 = \text{root}$ and v_m is a leaf satisfies:

$$\sum_{i=1}^{m} v_i.\text{data} = K$$

4.3 Algorithm: Recursive Subtraction

The key insight is to subtract the current node's value from K as we recurse, and check if $K = 0$ at a leaf:

```
boolean isPossible(TreeNode root, int K) {
   if (root == null) return false;

   // Leaf node: check if remaining K equals node value
   if (root.left == null && root.right == null) {
      return root.data == K;
   }

   // Recurse with reduced target
   boolean lans = isPossible(root.left,
                             K - root.data);
   if (lans) return true;  // Early termination

   boolean rans = isPossible(root.right,
                             K - root.data);
   return rans;
}
```

4.4 Why Check Only at Leaves?

Lemma 7 (Leaf-Only Termination). The path sum condition must be checked exclusively at leaf nodes. Checking at internal nodes would incorrectly count partial paths that do not extend to a leaf.

Proof. By definition, a root-to-leaf path must terminate at a leaf. If we return true at an internal node where the running sum equals K, we violate the constraint that the path must reach a leaf. □

4.5 Example and Dry Run

Dry Run with $K = 11$:

Node	Remaining K	Leaf?	$K = \text{data}$?	Result
5	11	No	—	recurse
4	$11 - 5 = 6$	No	—	recurse
2	$6 - 4 = 2$	Yes	$2 = 2$	true!

TABLE 2
Path sum trace for $K = 11$. Path $5 \to 4 \to 2$, sum $= 5 + 4 + 2 = 11$. Found!

Dry Run with $K = 22$ (no match):

4.6 Early Termination Optimization

The algorithm includes early termination: if lans is true, we skip the right subtree entirely. This is critical when the matching path is in the left subtree, reducing average-case work.

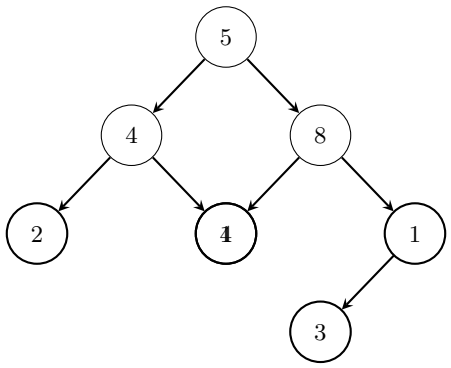

Fig. 2. Path Sum example tree.

Node	Remaining K	Leaf?	K = data?	Result
5	22	No	—	recurse
4	$22 - 5 = 17$	No	—	recurse
2	$17 - 4 = 13$	Yes	$2 \neq 13$	false
1	$17 - 4 = 13$	Yes	$1 \neq 13$	false
8	$22 - 5 = 17$	No	—	recurse
4	$17 - 8 = 9$	Yes	$4 \neq 9$	false
1	$17 - 8 = 9$	No	—	recurse
3	$9 - 1 = 8$	Yes	$3 \neq 8$	false

TABLE 3
Path sum trace for $K = 22$. No path sums to 22. Return false.

4.7 Complexity Analysis

- Time: $O(N)$ worst case (must explore all nodes if no match exists). Best case $O(\log N)$ with early termination on balanced trees.
- Space: $O(H)$ for the recursion stack.

5 Problem 3: Balanced Binary Tree Verification

5.1 Problem Statement

Determine whether a given binary tree is height-balanced: for every node v, $|h(v.\text{left}) - h(v.\text{right})| \leq 1$.

5.2 Naive Approach: $O(N^2)$

The straightforward approach computes the height at every node and checks the balance condition:

```
boolean isBalanced(TreeNode root) {
   if (root == null) return true;

   int lh = height(root.left);
   int rh = height(root.right);

   if (Math.abs(lh - rh) > 1) return false;

   return isBalanced(root.left)
      && isBalanced(root.right);
}

int height(TreeNode root) {
   if (root == null) return -1;
   return 1 + Math.max(height(root.left),
                       height(root.right));
}
```

Problem: For each node, height() traverses its entire subtree. For a skewed tree of N nodes, this leads to $O(N^2)$ time:

$$T(N) = N + (N-1) + (N-2) + \cdots + 1 = \frac{N(N+1)}{2} = O(N^2)$$

5.3 Optimized Approach: $O(N)$ Single-Pass

We combine height computation and balance checking into a single recursive pass. The key idea: if any subtree is unbalanced, propagate -1 as a sentinel:

```
boolean checkBalanced(TreeNode root) {
   return optimizedHeight(root) != -1;
}

int optimizedHeight(TreeNode root) {
   if (root == null) return 0;

   int lh = optimizedHeight(root.left);
   if (lh == -1) return -1;  // Left unbalanced

   int rh = optimizedHeight(root.right);
   if (rh == -1) return -1;  // Right unbalanced

   if (Math.abs(lh - rh) > 1) return -1;

   return 1 + Math.max(lh, rh);
}
```

Theorem 8 (Correctness of Optimized Balance Check). optimizedHeight(v) returns -1 if and only if the subtree rooted at v is not height-balanced. Otherwise, it returns the correct height of the subtree.

Proof. By structural induction on the tree.

Base case: $v = \text{null}$. Returns 0. The empty tree is trivially balanced. ✓

Inductive step: Assume the theorem holds for v.left and v.right.

Case 1: Left subtree is unbalanced $\Rightarrow \text{lh} = -1 \Rightarrow$ return -1. Since the subtree rooted at v contains an unbalanced subtree, the subtree of v is also unbalanced. ✓

Case 2: Right subtree is unbalanced $\Rightarrow \text{rh} = -1 \Rightarrow$ return -1. Same reasoning. ✓

Case 3: Both subtrees are balanced but $|\text{lh} - \text{rh}| > 1 \Rightarrow$ return -1. Node v itself violates the balance condition. ✓

Case 4: Both balanced and $|\text{lh} - \text{rh}| \leq 1 \Rightarrow$ return $1 + \max(\text{lh}, \text{rh})$, which is the correct height. ✓ □

5.4 Example and Dry Run

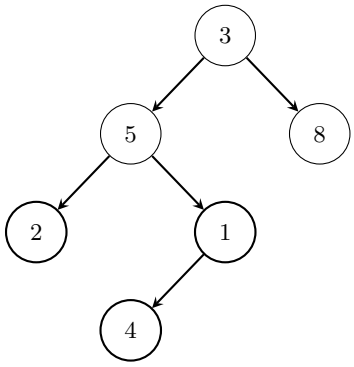

Fig. 3. Unbalanced tree: left subtree of root has height 3, right has height 1. $|3 - 1| = 2 > 1$.

Optimized Dry Run (Post-Order):

Node	lh	rh	$\lvert\text{lh}-\text{rh}\rvert$	Return
2 (leaf)	0	0	0	1
4 (leaf)	0	0	0	1
1	1 (from 4)	0	1	2
5	1 (from 2)	2 (from 1)	1	3
8 (leaf)	0	0	0	1
3 (root)	3 (from 5)	1 (from 8)	$2 > 1$	-1

TABLE 4
Optimized height computation with balance check. Tree is NOT balanced.

Approach	Time	Space
Naive (separate height + check)	$O(N^2)$	$O(H)$
Optimized (single pass with sentinel)	$O(N)$	$O(H)$

TABLE 5
Complexity comparison for balanced tree verification.

5.5 Complexity Comparison

6 Problem 4: Construct Binary Tree from Inorder and Postorder

6.1 Problem Statement

Given two integer arrays inorder[] and postorder[] representing the inorder and postorder traversals of a binary tree (with all values distinct), construct and return the binary tree.

6.2 Key Observations

Lemma 9 (Postorder Root Property). The last element of a postorder traversal is always the root of the tree (or subtree).

Lemma 10 (Inorder Partition Property). Given the root value, its position in the inorder array partitions the array into: elements of the left subtree (to the left of root) and elements of the right subtree (to the right of root).

Theorem 11 (Unique Reconstruction). A binary tree with distinct node values is uniquely determined by its inorder and postorder traversal sequences.

Proof. By structural induction. The postorder sequence identifies the root (last element). The inorder sequence, partitioned by the root, determines which elements belong to the left and right subtrees. By induction, each subtree is uniquely determined by its respective inorder and postorder subsequences. □

6.3 Algorithm

```
// Main entry point
TreeNode buildTree(int[] inorder, int[] postorder) {
    int n = inorder.length;
    return build(inorder, 0, n - 1,
                 postorder, 0, n - 1);
}

TreeNode build(int[] in, int li, int ri,
               int[] post, int lp, int rp) {
    // Base case: empty subtree
    if (li > ri || lp > rp) return null;

    // Root is the last element of postorder range
    int rootVal = post[rp];
    TreeNode root = new TreeNode(rootVal);

    // Find root's index in inorder array
    int rootIndex = -1;
    for (int i = li; i <= ri; i++) {
        if (in[i] == rootVal) {
            rootIndex = i;
            break;
        }
    }

    // Count elements in left subtree
    int leftCount = rootIndex - li;

    // Recursively build left and right subtrees
    root.left = build(in, li, rootIndex - 1,
                      post, lp, lp + leftCount - 1);
    root.right = build(in, rootIndex + 1, ri,
                       post, lp + leftCount, rp - 1);
```

```
    return root;
}
```

6.4 Index Mapping Derivation

The critical step is computing the correct postorder index ranges for the left and right subtrees. Given:

- Inorder range: $[\text{li}, \text{ri}]$
- Postorder range: $[\text{lp}, \text{rp}]$ (with root at rp)
- Root index in inorder: rootIndex
- Left subtree size: $\text{leftCount} = \text{rootIndex} - \text{li}$

Subtree	Inorder Range	Postorder Range
Left	$[\text{li},\ \text{rootIndex} - 1]$	$[\text{lp},\ \text{lp} + \text{leftCount} - 1]$
Right	$[\text{rootIndex} + 1,\ \text{ri}]$	$[\text{lp} + \text{leftCount},\ \text{rp} - 1]$

TABLE 6
Index range derivation for recursive subtree construction.

6.5 HashMap Optimization

The linear search for rootIndex makes the naive algorithm $O(N^2)$ in the worst case. We optimize by pre-building a HashMap:

```
TreeNode buildTreeOptimized(int[] inorder,
                            int[] postorder) {
    HashMap<Integer, Integer> indexMap = new HashMap<>();
    for (int i = 0; i < inorder.length; i++) {
        indexMap.put(inorder[i], i);
    }
    return buildOpt(inorder, 0, inorder.length - 1,
                    postorder, 0, postorder.length - 1,
                    indexMap);
}
```

With the HashMap, root index lookup becomes $O(1)$, reducing total time to $O(N)$.

6.6 Detailed Example

Given:

- $\text{inorder} = [4, 2, 5, 7, 1, 3, 6]$
- $\text{postorder} = [4, 7, 5, 2, 6, 3, 1]$

Step-by-step construction:

1) post[6] = 1 is the root. In inorder, 1 is at index 4.
2) Left subtree: in[0..3] = [4, 2, 5, 7], post[0..3] = [4, 7, 5, 2].
3) Right subtree: in[5..6] = [3, 6], post[4..5] = [6, 3].
4) For left subtree: post[3] = 2 is root. In inorder, 2 is at index 1.
   - Left of 2: in[0..0] = [4], post[0..0] = [4] $\Rightarrow$ leaf 4.
   - Right of 2: in[2..3] = [5, 7], post[1..2] = [7, 5].
5) For in[2..3], post[2] = 5 is root. Index of 5 in inorder is 2.
   - Left of 5: empty.
   - Right of 5: in[3..3] = [7] $\Rightarrow$ leaf 7.
6) For right subtree of root: post[5] = 3 is root. Index of 3 in inorder is 5.
   - Left of 3: empty.
   - Right of 3: in[6..6] = [6] $\Rightarrow$ leaf 6.

Reconstructed tree:
Verification:

- Inorder (LNR): $4 \to 2 \to 5 \to 7 \to 1 \to 3 \to 6$ ✓
- Postorder (LRN): $4 \to 7 \to 5 \to 2 \to 6 \to 3 \to 1$ ✓

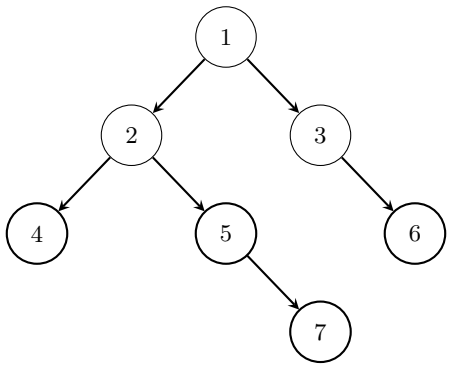

Fig. 4. Reconstructed tree from inorder $[4, 2, 5, 7, 1, 3, 6]$ and postorder $[4, 7, 5, 2, 6, 3, 1]$.

Call	in range	post range	Root	leftCount
1	[0,6]	[0,6]	1	4
2	[0,3]	[0,3]	2	1
3	[0,0]	[0,0]	4 (leaf)	0
4	[2,3]	[1,2]	5	0
5	[3,3]	[1,1]	7 (leaf)	0
6	[5,6]	[4,5]	3	0
7	[6,6]	[4,4]	6 (leaf)	0

TABLE 7
Recursive call sequence for tree construction.

6.7 Recursive Call Tree Visualization

6.8 Complexity Analysis

7 Comprehensive Complexity Summary

8 Conclusion

This paper presented formal analyses of four advanced binary tree problems: Equal Tree Partition, Root-to-Leaf Path Sum, Balanced Binary Tree Verification, and Tree Construction from Inorder and Postorder Traversals. Each algorithm was developed with rigorous correctness proofs using structural induction, detailed dry-run traces with TikZ-rendered tree visualizations, and comprehensive complexity analyses.

Key takeaways include:

- Equal Partition: Reduces to finding a subtree with sum equal to half the total — an elegant application of the subtree sum property.
- Path Sum: Demonstrates the power of recursive parameter reduction (subtracting node values from the target) with leaf-only termination.
- Balance Check: The sentinel-based single-pass approach achieves $O(N)$ vs. the naive $O(N^2)$, illustrating how combining computations eliminates redundant traversals.
- Tree Construction: The HashMap optimization converts $O(N^2)$ to $O(N)$ by replacing linear search with constant-time lookup — a technique applicable to many divide-and-conquer algorithms.

Variant	Time	Space
Linear search for root index	$O(N^2)$ worst case	$O(H)$
HashMap-based root index lookup	$O(N)$	$O(N)$

TABLE 8
Complexity comparison for tree construction.

Problem	Time	Space	Technique
Equal Tree Partition	$O(N)$	$O(H)$	Two-pass subtree sum
Root-to-Leaf Path Sum	$O(N)$	$O(H)$	DFS with subtraction
Balanced Tree (Naive)	$O(N^2)$	$O(H)$	Separate height calls
Balanced Tree (Optimized)	$O(N)$	$O(H)$	Sentinel propagation
Tree Construction (Naive)	$O(N^2)$	$O(H)$	Linear root search
Tree Construction (HashMap)	$O(N)$	$O(N)$	Pre-built index map

TABLE 9
Complete complexity summary. N = number of nodes, H = tree height.

These problems form a critical foundation for advanced topics including Lowest Common Ancestor (LCA), tree serialization/deserialization, and dynamic programming on trees.

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